

PERHAPS

***Blue denotes power point slide**

***Brown denotes instructions to technician**

TEXT: 1 Samuel 14:1-10 (NIV) *“One day Jonathan son of Saul said to his young armor-bearer, “Come, let’s go over to the Philistine outpost on the other side.” But he did not tell his father. ² Saul was staying on the outskirts of Gibeah under a pomegranate tree in Migron. With him were about six hundred men, ³ among whom was Ahijah, who was wearing an ephod. He was a son of Ichabod’s brother Ahitub son of Phinehas, the son of Eli, the LORD’s priest in Shiloh. No one was aware that Jonathan had left. ⁴ On each side of the pass that Jonathan intended to cross to reach the Philistine outpost was a cliff; one was called Bozez and the other Seneh. ⁵ One cliff stood to the north toward Mikdash, the other to the south toward*

Geba. ⁶ Jonathan said to his young armor-bearer, “Come, let’s go over to the outpost of those uncircumcised men. Perhaps the LORD will act in our behalf. Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few.” ⁷ “Do all that you have in mind,” his armor-bearer said. “Go ahead; I am with you heart and soul.” ⁸ Jonathan said, “Come on, then; we will cross over toward them and let them see us. ⁹ If they say to us, ‘Wait there until we come to you,’ we will stay where we are and not go up to them. ¹⁰ But if they say, ‘Come up to us,’ we will climb up, because that will be our sign that the LORD has given them into our hands.”

INTRO: In 1 Samuel chapters thirteen and fourteen, we read that the army of King Saul had been locked in on the losing side of a standoff against the Philistines for a significant period of time.

Standoffs are where dreams languish and the flames of greatness flicker and die. Nothing good ever comes of a standoff. Valuable time is lost in a standoff.

The truth is, much time is spent in personal standoffs as we struggle with what we should do and what God is really saying. The truth is, God would rather us be a little quick on the trigger than to continually be paralyzed by the fear of failure.

I know individuals and leaders that are afraid of their own shadow and consequently their destiny and the ability of their organizations are doomed to mediocrity.

I. PERHAPS WE ARE INTIMIDATED...

Based on the fire- power and the lopsided numbers against them the standoff was intimidating to the Israelis. The Scriptures make us aware that what they were facing

was 30,000 of the best chariots pulled by thoroughbred horses and 6,000 soldiers riding the best horses money could buy. The foot soldiers are described by the author *“As the sand which is on the sea shore in multitude.”* (I Samuel 13:5)

Here is the problem: 30,000 chariots driven by the best trained warriors in the land + 6,000 of the best horses ridden by fierce soldiers + an innumerable host of well trained foot soldiers – To – 3,000 rag tag soldiers none of whom were in possession of a sword or spear, except Jonathan and Saul! Are you scared? I am! Anyone in his or her right mind would be!

Add to the intimidation, the fact that the Philistines were perched on the highest ground available which made defending themselves much easier, and anyone who dared attack them much more vulnerable.

I do not know what intimidating task stands before each of you today, but I do know that God can “*Save by many, or by few.*”

I would like us to do some soul searching today and ask ourselves the question, what am I most intimidated about? If we were not afraid of failing, what one thing would we attempt immediately?

As we step by faith into our future, I am sure there will be an intimidation factor from the enemy. We must make up our minds here and now that we will not be ruled by fear, that faith will win the day!

Apparently Saul's troops were passing the time looking for better caves to hide in. 1 Samuel 13:6 (NIV) “***When the Israelites saw that their situation was critical and that their army was hard pressed, they hid in caves and thickets, among the rocks, and in pits and cisterns.***” [Paul Tournier](#) in his

book *The Strong And The Weak* say's, "*All of us have reservoirs of full potential, vast areas of great satisfaction. But the roads that lead to those reservoirs are guarded by the dragon of fear.*" **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL POINT 2 – PERHAPS WE SHOULD TAKE ACTION)**

God does not want you personally nor this church corporately to be sitting in this room twelve months from now examining the what-if's of the past twelve months. He wants you to be celebrating the intervention of a God who can "*deliver by many or by few.*"

II. PERHAPS WE SHOULD TAKE ACTION...

Eventually, Jonathan, the king's son, became so irritated with the fear and inaction of himself and his fellow warriors that he decided to make a bold move. He enlisted his armor bearer to join him on a two-man

commando raid. 1 Samuel 14:1 (NIV) *“One day Jonathan son of Saul said to his young armor-bearer, “Come, let’s go over to the Philistine outpost on the other side.”* Put yourself in Jonathan’s place, shoot, put yourself in the armor-bearers place!

What bold move must we make to break out of what we have been in for far too long? Are we willing to keep wallowing in the defeats of the past? Or are we ready to risk life and limb to finally slay the dragon that has been keeping us back from our destiny?

What bold move is God going to call this church to make to cause it to become the church of His purpose? Are you ready?

Jonathans battle plan was:

- A bit sketchy...
- Potentially God inspired...
- More than a little ludicrous...

Here is the plan – Are you ready for this? Jonathan and his armor bearer would radio for some war planes to drop some bombs on the Philistines - followed by helicopters airlifting a group of special forces to the sight - and to finish the job; troops climbing up the mountain from all sides to kill the escaping soldiers.

That would be risky enough for me but listen to this: Jonathan and his armor-bearer would openly approach the enemy outpost. If they got a go-ahead sign from God, they would attack. What was the sign? **1 Samuel 14:9-10 (NIV) “If they say to us, ‘Wait there until we come to you,’ we will stay where we are and not go up to them. ¹⁰ But if they say, ‘Come up to us,’ we will climb up, because that will be our sign that the LORD has given them into our hands.”** The sign from God would come out of the mouth of an hyper-confident enemy! They were going to make their final decision based on

whether a hyper-confident enemy responded for the two of them to stay where they were, or to bring the battle to them!

I think I would want a sign to be that half the forces of the Philistines to be killed by a freak lightning storm. The bottom line is this, Jonathan was bone tired of looking for a better cave to live in, He was looking for a green light to attack this formidable foe, rather than a red light to bide his time.

What could happen if God's people and God's church became so tired of the status quo that we were more inclined to jump-the-gun rather than miss-our-moment? The fact is that the Lord responds to audacious faith and God is more inclined to rescue the jump-the-gunners than to protect the misers-of-the-moment!

Outnumbered; outmanned; and under-resourced Jonathan and his armor-bearer

made a fateful decision to attempt to turn the fortunes of the nation. For sure, this was a borderline suicide mission. In the mind of Jonathan, he figured their present situation was unacceptable and if the Lord were to work on their behalf, nothing could stop them.

In his opinion death would be better than mediocrity! Mediocrity is the neutering of personal destiny and corporate victories!

What will the future look like for our personal destiny and corporate journey if we decide to launch an all out attack on the dragon that has been keeping us from what we know the Lord has for us?

“The Lord will save by many or by few!”

III. PERHAPS THE LORD WILL HELP US...

Jonathan probably believed his greatest challenge would be to persuade his bodyguard that there was a chance the mission could succeed.

The fear of rejection keeps:

- Families from being what they could be...
- Individuals from doing what they are called to do...
- Leaders from projecting vision to those who are following...
- Churches from taking the steps necessary to reach the masses...

Listen to the words of Jonathan's motivational speech to an audience of one: I Samuel 14:6 (NIV) ***"Come, let's go over to the outpost of those uncircumcised fellows. Perhaps the LORD will act in our behalf. Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few."***

Jonathan appeared to be sending the ultimate mixed message! If you were trying to convince me to join you in an initiative this dangerous, I would certainly want you to do better than "*perhaps the LORD will act in our behalf.*" Perhaps? Perhaps?

Jonathan seemed to be speaking out of both sides of his mouth. In one breath he communicated two opposing positions:

- Nothing can hinder the LORD...
- Perhaps the LORD will act...

At first glance, this seems like spiritual schizophrenia. On the other hand, maybe Jonathan wasn't as far off as he seemed. True faith always feels this way: on one hand, I know that God is able to do anything, on the other hand, I think he's willing to do this specific thing.

I know God can and I'm pretty sure that he will! But I can't be completely sure can I?

Sometimes I can know for sure and other times I have to step out on nothing but faith!

I love the times when God speaks to me and there is no doubt. I have no problem obeying in those moments. I rarely tell anyone “*God said*” because I want it to mean something when I do. When I do speak a word over someone I always follow it with a question like “*Does that ring true to you?*” Or “*Does that make sense to you?*” When someone wants to speak a word over me, I usually say, “*Let’s try it on for size.*”

Where I struggle in my personal life and as a leader of a church is when we are called upon to take the next logical step by faith!

This is the challenge of taking charge of our destiny and deciding nothing will keep us from what God has for us. For our lives to

fulfill God's design we will have to become risk-takers!

There comes a time to act on what God is saying, or to miss the moment, and this can mean the difference between fulfillment and failure.

This is also the challenge of following a visionary leader: no leader has a 100% success rate! When you are following a visionary, “*perhaps*” is the constant in your life. (Angel food – Health Fair - Pasadena)

I wonder what each church would be if the Pastor never had to consider what the reaction of the crowd would be with regard to vision casting or implementation? What if the church body said to the Pastor “***Do all that is in your heart, we are with you heart and soul***”? What if the pastor knew that if the plan did not succeed he would not be

judged harshly, but the people would say,
“this didn’t work, what should we try next?”

Followers should never judge leaders more harshly than they wish to be judged! ***“Judge not, that you be not judged. For whatever measurement you use to judge the same will be used to judge you.”***

- Do you want your wife and family to judge you with the same severity you have used to judge your church leaders?
- Do you want your employer to judge you as harshly as you have judged your Pastor?
- Do you want your employees to judge you with the same judgment you have used to judge church leadership?

The fact is that it takes very little faith to act when we have heard the booming voice of God, but audacious faith is required to take the next logical step by faith. Audacious faith isn't the absence of uncertainty and

ambiguity, audacious faith is being able to believe God's promise is bigger than my "*perhaps*"!

Remember, the Bible proclaims "*His Word is a lamp unto my feet and a light unto my path.*" **(WHEN I QUOTE THIS SCRIPTURE TURN OFF ALL THE LIGHTS IN THE ROOM AT ONCE. LEAVE THE LIGHTS OFF UNTIL I TURN THE FLASHLIGHT OFF)**

His Word is lamp and a light, not a floodlight beaming all the way to our destination.

Sometimes we are called upon to step out in simple faith and do something we have not done before. In those moments God will either teach us to fly or provide a soft landing strip because he honors faith!

A visionary leader steps to the podium armed with the confidence that there's a decent chance and an interesting possibility that this idea might be from God! A visionary lives in a world of “*perhaps*”! Those who follow a visionary leader have to learn to live in the world of “*perhaps*”!

Jonathan acted in a visionary fashion, asking for the impossible and operating in the uncertain arena of “*perhaps*”! He knew that looking for better caves to hide in had no real future but if they acted and his “*perhaps*” received the favor of the Lord, the upside potential would be off the chain!

As a church we will be called upon to operate in the world of “*perhaps*” believing God's agenda is far bigger than our “*perhaps*”!

Jonathan believed his greatest challenge would be to get his armor-bearer to join him

on this risky venture. Listen to the response of Jonathan's armor bearer, 1 Samuel 14 :7 (NKJV) *"Do all that is in your heart. Go then; here I am with you, according to your heart."* This guy's life and future is on the line here but he decided to step out in audacious faith to follow a visionary leader!

As it turns out, Jonathan's greatest challenge was getting himself ready! The armor bearer was just waiting on his leader to make a decision and the battle had already been decided because God was against the Philistines and for Israel!

Most people spend 90% of their times working up the courage to share their vision with those who need to know. Most of this time is spent wallowing in the fear of possibly being rejected or shot down!

Leaders squander valuable time sorting out the, what if's. What we should be doing is

laying out the plan for the future! When God set's a direction He also provides armor-bearers that are not afraid to charge hell with a water pistol!

A visionary leader is not a one-hundred-percenter! God calls some of us to provide leadership and some of us to provide followship, but make no mistake about it; the same amount of faith is required at both levels!

David and his armor bearer killed twenty men (on a half acre) on this particular day and got the Philistines on the run, and when the rest of the Israeli army saw what was happening they joined in, and the task that had looked so formidable became one of the great victories in the national history of Israel!

What difficult thing will God call us to do? Becoming the church to reach the city is a

daunting challenge but “*perhaps the LORD will be with us!*”

CONCLUSION:

Let me take this one step further: What is going on with your personal “*perhaps*”?

Let me give you some pointers concerning your personal “*perhaps*”:

1. Be honest about your “*perhaps*”. Be honest with God and with others.
2. Acknowledge and deal appropriately with your fears.
3. Approach your impossibilities with confident humility.
4. Pray that God will give you assurance of his presence and clarity in every decision you make.
5. Have faith in His promises.
6. Keep yourself tightly connected to Him.
7. Be assured that He's got you in his grip.

If you're not daring to believe God for the impossible, you're sleeping through some of the best parts of your Christian life!

“Perhaps the LORD will be with you.”

PLACES PREACHED:

CT Church Houston TX 2/13

Faith AG Texarkana AR 4/13

1st A/G Russellville AR 7/13

Hillcrest A/G Seguin TX 7/13

CT Gulfgate Houston TX 9/22/13

1st A/G Neederland TX 9/29/13